

the room consist of 10-foot-deep pits covered with square steel grates, and are heavy with the scent of rot. Two tall, pixelated archways lead out of the room.

Unpixelated. The reliefs can be identified as black and red dragons, carved in red marble and basalt. The bases of all the statues are engraved in Draconic with hymns to Tiamat.

Place of Sacrifice. When the cube was a functional fortress, the eight oubliettes were used to store sacrifices and food for the abishai priests of Tiamat who controlled this temple. The sacrifice pits contain sand and bits of humanoid remains.

When the pixelating curse overcame the fortress, the temple of Tiamat remained untainted through the power of the dragon queen. This antechamber was too far from the center of that power to have been affected, but midway along the corridor to area 6.38, the walls and floor unpixelate, gradually changing from a blocky mosaic to natural black granite.

AREA 6.37: PRIESTS' BARRACKS

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. A central corridor opens up between numerous black metal doors set with small, square-barred windows. Most windows reveal small rooms beyond that contain a number of indistinct, blocky objects, but a few rooms are empty and finished in white tile. Several blocky machines stand in the main area, which is lit by white glowing bricks in the walls. A number of crudely humanoid, cubic bodies of black and gray are spread across the floor with mosaic-like black stains spilling out around them. The area smells of rot.

Unpixelated. These were meditation chambers and personal quarters for priests of Bane and Loviatar. Each individual room contains a low table, a simple toilet and sink, and personal items such as priestly robes, maces, and holy symbols. The white-tiled chamber is a slime shower and the machines are food devices, all similar to those seen in area 6.11. The doors to individual rooms have no locks.

The rotting remains of the dead priests, killed in the assault on the cube, lie on the floor in pools of dried blood.

AREA 6.38: GREAT TEMPLE OF TIAMAT

This chamber was the temple of Tiamat, one of the gods worshiped by the soldiers and lords of the cube. Thanks to the power of the holy idol here, the temple was able to resist the pixelating curse that has swallowed all other areas of the cube.

Entering this area reveals a vault-like chamber walled in black granite, whose ceiling rises out of sight 100 feet overhead. Human skulls glowing with the light of *continual flame* spells are set on pedestals across the room and hang from the walls to fill the area with bright light.

In the center of the room stands a great brass pool filled with burning oil. At the far end of the chamber is a large bloodstained obsidian statue of Tiamat—a



BLACK ABISHAI

monstrous dragon with five heads whose eyes are glittering gems. A number of items are set at the base of the statue, along with piles of glittering coins. A smell of burned meat and incense fills the air.

Abishai Assault. The temple's most powerful priests survived the assault on the cube: seven **white abishai**^M and one **black abishai**^M. Not allied in any way with the skull lord, these infernal dragons have been seeking a way to escape the cube since the assault, along with sacrifices to Tiamat for protecting them from the pixelating curse. When not scouting the cube for these things, they rest here.

If the characters entered area 6.36 with any light or noise, the abishai flew up to cling to the ceiling. When they party enters this area, they attack with surprise.

Relics and Retribution. In their explorations of the cube, the abishai have gathered treasure and left it as offerings at the foot of the idol: 2,250 gp, 752 sp, and a *tentacle rod* left behind by a fallen drow.

The idol of Tiamat radiates powerful magic and evil. If the abishai kill a creature, they drain its blood onto the idol while singing hymns to Tiamat, then consume the sacrifice. The idol's gem eyes are worth 2,000 gp each (for a total of 20,000 gp). However, any attempt to remove the eyes or otherwise damage the statue causes an **eidolon** (in the form of a howling, ghostly abishai) to rise from the fiery pool. The eidolon enters the **sacred statue** of Tiamat, which animates to attack all non-devils in the temple. See *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes* for more information on the eidolon and the sacred statue.

If the sacred statue is destroyed, the fire in the brass pool goes out and the room's protective aura is

dispelled. This causes the pixelating curse to reshape the temple in 1 hour.

A Refreshing Dip. While it burns, the fiery pool of oil radiates transmutation magic and evil, but it channels the same power that prevents the pixelating curse from transforming the temple. The abishai regularly bathe in the oil, which cures them of the pixelating curse if they contracted it elsewhere on the cube. Any creature can submerge itself in the burning oil, which drains 1 physical level and 1 mental level of the pixelating curse at the end of each of the creature's turns. The curse is removed when the creature reaches physical level 0. However, any non-abishai that enters the pool takes 14 (4d6) fire damage at the start of each of its turns.

AREA 6.39: BOTTOM OF THE RIFT

As the characters approach this room, they hear a scream that gets suddenly louder, then ends in a bone-crushing thump. If they wait in the hall, the pattern of sound repeats every six seconds. See area 6.14 for more information.

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. Some massive force has torn open the roof of this chamber, revealing huge pixelated steel girders and pipes, and creating a great hole that opens up to darkness overhead. In the center of this area, below the hole, a pile of unpixelated bodies rises twenty feet high.

Unpixelated. The shattered girders and pipes reveal the deadly sharpness of their edges.

Death From Above. Adults of every race and gender are represented among the dead. Most are human, but gnomes, dwarves, and other creatures can also be seen. All are naked, and appear to have died from the fall. Every six seconds, a screaming humanoid falls from the darkness and smashes into the top of the pile of bodies, where it dies of massive trauma. Characters who attempt to climb to the top of the pile are at risk of being struck by a falling body, and must succeed on a DC 16 Dexterity saving throw each round or take 17 (5d6) bludgeoning damage.

Bodies that fall here become infected by the pixelating curse, and characters who inspect the pile see that the bodies at the bottom (those that have been here the longest) are beginning to turn cubic. However, the bodies are regularly cleaned up by the hellfire engine that patrols this area (see area 6.41). If the hellfire engine is destroyed, the bodies rapidly begin to pile up, pixelate, and spread out at a rate of six hundred bodies per hour. Within four hours, this area becomes impassable. Over a longer period, the entire lower level—and eventually the entire cube—will be filled.

Interrupted Fall. The characters might attempt to rescue one or more of the falling individuals, using spells such as *feather fall* or *telekinesis*. If they are successful, see area 6.14 for more information.

AREA 6.40: WIRING SHAFTS

Much smaller than normal corridors, these narrow spaces are filled with wires and pipes that occasionally emit heat and steam. A Small creature can squeeze into a wiring shaft with a successful DC 20 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check, which must be made at each new area or junction. With a failed check, the character can peek into the area beyond but not enter it.

These access spaces for the cube's machinery were once used by duergar and gnome technicians. A creative character might attempt to damage the cube by unleashing powerful spells or attacks here. Anything less than a 9th-level spell is unlikely to seriously harm the cube, but might cause a distraction that the pixelated guards will investigate.

AREA 6.41: PUMP ROOM

Pixelated or unpixelated, the appearance of this room is much the same: a great factory-like space filled with pumps, valves, and pipes. Most of the pipes lead into area 6.47, where they force water and debris into the exhaust shaft to be expelled.

Cleaning Crew. This room is dominated by a massive, boxy metal device with terrifying bestial mouths carved into it—a pixelated **hellfire engine**^M modified by Avnas for cleaning duty. This gigantic construct regularly clears out the lower levels, rolling down the



main corridor to suck up bodies, debris, and small amounts of Styx water before returning here to shoot them through pipes into area 6.47. It has the statistics of a hellfire engine (including all of its attacks) with the following changes:

- Its alignment is lawful neutral.
- It has telepathy out to a range of 120 feet, but can use it to communicate only with other pixelated creatures. Being unintelligent, it can communicate only emotions and vague feelings.
- It has advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks made to hide while in a pixelated area.

The hellfire engine recognizes devils and servants of the skull lord, and attacks all other creatures on sight. Because of its size, the hellfire engine cannot leave the wide main corridor that runs around the lower level. However, it can attack creatures in nearby areas using its ranged weapons, liquefying foes with its Bonemelt Sprayer and sucking up any remains that flow into the main hall. If the construct sees an enemy go into a room it can't reach, it waits for them to come out as long as it can see them. If a creature goes out of its range and out of vision, the hellfire engine waits for 10 minutes, then goes back to its rounds.

AREA 6.42: DEATH TRAP

This area is an empty guardroom, similar to area 6.8 and the area 6.33 rooms on this level. It has an interior door leading to area 5.1, and a faint mosaic stain of small pink, white, and red cubes the spread across the walls and floor. The stain appears to have been scrubbed or wiped away in the center of the room, but nonetheless marks a distinct path between area 5.1 and area 6.43. A smell of rotten meat can also be sensed in the direction of area 6.43.

Creatures that slip and fall as a result of the gravity switch in area 5.2 drop nearly 600 feet and land here, taking 20d6 bludgeoning damage. The pixelated adult oblex of area 5.1 spends some of its time here eating fallen bodies, but the hellfire engine (area 6.41) cleans up most of the mess. With a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Survival) check, a character confirms that the trail has been left by a slimy creature moving back and forth through this area.

AREA 6.43: TORTURE CHAMBER/OBLEX ROOM

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. Strange objects made of thick gray, black, and brown blocks fill this room. Some resemble tables, but their surfaces are irregular. Others look like upright cases or trunks big enough to walk into, while still others resemble siege equipment or oversized birdcages. Strange square mosaics mark the walls, and the floor is covered with irregular encrustations of black cubes, like a crystalline growth marked by occasional dark-green stains.

Unpixelated. The unknown objects within the room are all torture equipment—cruel devices beyond mortal imagination. The markings on the walls are symbols of Loviatar, goddess of pain.

The dark encrustation is a squishy slime excreted by the oblex spawn that feed in this area. Indigestible fragments are scattered within it, including bits of armor and chunks of yellow bone. The darker masses among the slime are eight pixelated **oblex spawn**^M, which wait for prey to enter the room before swarming from all directions.

If injured, the **adult oblex**^M at area 5.1 retreats to this room, where its spawn reinforce it.

AREA 6.44: TEMPLE OF LOVIATAR

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. The floor of this high-ceilinged chamber is lined with rows of what appear to be flat, square scales of glittering glass. At one end of the chamber stands a blocky pedestal, from which a black and white pixelated humanoid statue has fallen. Several faceless, blocky bodies lie on the floor, and the stench of rot hangs in the air.

Unpixelated. The statue depicts a woman with a beautiful and cruel face holding a whip—Loviatar, goddess of pain and consort of Bane. The scales on the floor are trenches filled with broken glass, which is deadly sharp and merely appears flat due to the pixelating curse. A creature that steps on the broken glass in bare feet or soft shoes takes 2 (1d4) piercing damage per 5 feet traveled.

The temple has been desecrated by the worshipers of the Archquadrone. The bodies of Loviatar's priests lie on the floor. All carry whips, daggers, and holy symbols, but nothing of value.

AREA 6.45: BERBALANG'S ROOM

This area is identical to the priests' barracks at area 6.37, except that one room here is used as a lair by Bunch, the skull lord's **berbalang**^M ally. If the characters have not already met and destroyed Bunch, the **berbalang** is here counting its bones.

The **berbalang**'s lair is filled with pixelated yellowish-gray skulls and bones to a depth of 4 feet, with duergar, gnome, and human remains the most common. Bunch obsessively sorts through its collection for hours on end, using *speak with dead* to mine the memories the skulls contain, then scribing those tales on the other bones. Bunch is protective of these treasures, and the **berbalang** runs to alert the skull lord if the characters mess with its collection.

Any character who searches the bones and succeeds on a DC 20 Wisdom (Perception) check finds a *ring of free action* within the pile.

AREA 6.46: TEMPLE OF LADUGUER

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. This wide chamber features a ceiling that is lower than the corridor outside. The floor is covered with rows of trenches, which surround a central heap of gray and black metallic cubes. Here and there, the trenches are darkly stained, and all around the room lie short, blocky figures from which the stench of rot rises.

Unpixelated. Duergar dead are scattered throughout what was once a temple to the duergar deity Laduguer,

Master of Crafts. The central heap is Laduguer's iron idol, which has been completely smashed. Only a close inspection identifies a few limbs and the crushed remains of the statue's beard.

AREA 6.47: EXHAUST SHAFT

This roughly pixelated circular shaft rises nearly 200 feet from the oily pool at area 1.1 to the Heart Engine at area 6.28 far above. The temperature is warm here, and gets hotter as the shaft rises toward area 6.28. The shaft is dimly lit by red lights seen high above.

Characters who enter the cube from area 1.1 can climb or fly to the Heart Engine (although thick pipes block the engine from view until they reach it). The walls are slick with warm slime pouring down from a multitude of exhaust pipes and grates, making climbing difficult, but the cubic surfaces of the pixelated walls counteract this somewhat.

Going Up. Climbing the 300 feet between this area and area 6.28 requires six successful DC 20 Strength (Athletics) checks. On a failed check, a creature falls and takes damage as normal.

A character who enters the bottom of the shaft and succeeds on a DC 12 Wisdom (Perception) check notices a number of dry pipes that are just barely large enough for a Small creature to crawl into. With a successful DC 20 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check, a Small character can enter the wiring shafts (area 6.40).

The exhaust shaft periodically rumbles as black cubical slime and pixelated bodies pour out of its side pipes, then explode out through the pool at area 1.1 in a geyser of pressure and heat. If any character rolls a 1 on the Strength check to climb, the exhaust shaft begins to rumble and shake as the pressure builds. Two rounds later, the pressure wave hits, dealing 21 (6d6) fire damage and 21 (6d6) bludgeoning damage to every creature in the shaft or in area 6.47. Each of those creatures must then succeed on a DC 18 Strength saving throw or be flung out of the shaft onto face 1.

The proximity to the Heart Engine makes the pixelating curse stronger within the shaft than outside it. While in the shaft, creatures must make all checks and saving throws related to the curse every 10 minutes, rather than at the end of each short rest. A creature that reaches physical level 2 while climbing the shaft has disadvantage on Strength checks as a result of the sudden transformation of its hands into rough, cubical mittens.

ENDING THE ADVENTURE

Depending on their interactions with Vargo and their ultimate choice about what to do about the threat represented by Cube 1717, the characters might bring the adventure to a number of different conclusions.

VARGO AWAKENS THE CUBE

If Vargo manages to attune to all six parts of the Six-Face Throne, the skull lord reveals its new goal: the conquest of the Sword Coast. The cube is flown to the nearest city, where Vargo demands that the inhabitants surrender to its will—then blasts them with the cube cannon until they submit.

Any injured survivors of the cube cannon quickly pixelate, becoming additional soldiers under Vargo's control. Gradually, the skull lord's pixelated army grows, and the very landscape of the realm is transformed. Some lands resist Vargo, while others send offerings of gold, jewels, and magic items to be spared from the skull lord's destructive wrath and the pixel plague. The Sword Coast descends into darkness and terror.

PIXELS TRIUMPHANT

If Vargo is killed but another pixelated creature (including Sladek) remains alive and attuned to the Six-Face Throne, all the pixelated creatures of the cube telepathically confer among themselves. In truth, they never fully trusted Vargo because of the skull lord's unpixelated state. So with that undead master gone, its former followers can carry out their own plan: peacefully turning the entire world into pixels and spreading the glorious gift of the Archquadrone.

All pixelated creatures on the cube immediately converge on the Six-Face Throne, ready to attune to it or die trying. If enough of them are successful, the cube awakens and they send it flying away from the Styx sea. The cube lands in different spots on Faerûn, dropping off small groups of pixelated creatures to infect the land, the local vegetation, and all nearby creatures.

DESTRUCTION OF THE HEART ENGINE

The only way to truly stop the pixelating curse is to destroy the Heart Engine. When the Heart Engine reaches 0 hit points (or if it is completely immersed in the Styx sea), it explodes. A wave of energy sweeps out from it, unpixelating everything in and on the cube. Any surviving pixelated creatures come back to their senses.

With the Heart Engine gone, the Six-Face Throne stops functioning as well. The entire interior of the cube goes dark as its power fails and it sinks into the depths of the sea, never to rise again. If the characters are in the cube when this happens, you can decide how fast the cube sinks—and how perilous a time they have getting out before it's completely submerged and flooded.

After the characters return to port, word of their exploits will quickly spread, and the dark tale will be told of what the pixelating curse might have done had it been allowed to run unchecked. If the adventurers don't already have a reputation as legendary heroes, they soon will, as all the folk of the Sword Coast learn of how the characters saved the world from a terrible fate. **D**

Design and Cartography: Jason Bradley Thompson
Editing, Development, and Layout for *Dragon+*:
Scott Fitzgerald Gray

A full-size map of Face 6 is [available for download](#).